

Chapter 124-3

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Endless, boundless darkness, even her head felt heavy and stuffy.

There was the smell of freshly turned earth—it must be raining.

Yet in this endless darkness, she seemed to hear the sound of ocean waves rolling. For a moment, she even thought she had arrived at the seaside.

Her body was limp and powerless, her eyelids felt like they weighed a thousand pounds and wouldn't open no matter what.

Xu Qingzhu heard rustling sounds but couldn't distinguish what was making the noise.

Even though she was dressed warmly enough, she still felt cold in this environment.

She sniffled and could smell the damp, briny scent in the air—very much like the smell of the sea, yet not as strong.

Every time it rained heavily in Haizhou City, this smell would appear in the air.

Xu Qingzhu used all her strength to barely open her eyes, but her body had no strength at all. She was like a soft ball of cotton—even if someone punched her, she wouldn't react.

Both her body and head were groggy and muddled—it must be the effect of drugs.

Her nape felt a dull ache, especially the patch of skin at the back of her neck, which seemed to have no sensation, just like being given anesthesia before surgery.

But this anesthetic probably contained more than just painkillers—there was something else making her unable to exert any strength.

Also, her back was being pressed against something hard and painful, and she could feel coldness and dampness.

Even though she had struggled with all her might to open her eyes, everything before her was still pitch black.

Her mouth was also taped shut, sealed tightly. Her hands and feet were all bound. If she wanted to move now, she could probably only use her bottom to propel her body and hop, or use her waist and abdominal strength to squat then stand up, then jump forward with both feet together.

But this was extremely difficult.

Xu Qingzhu didn't exercise often, and her constitution was poor. Now with her eyes blindfolded, trapped in a dark and damp place, she kept telling herself in her heart not to be afraid—she was no longer the child she used to be.

But fear still surged up endlessly from the depths of her heart.

She was afraid, terrified. She wanted to escape this environment, wanted to see light, wanted to bask in the sun.

Memories from many years ago kept flooding into her mind, overlapping with the current scene. She gripped her own palm tightly, her fingernails almost digging into the flesh. She hypnotized herself: It's okay, someone will come to save me, the kidnapper won't do anything to me.

It was useless.

The psychological defenses she had built up over so many years were teetering on the verge of collapse. Her reason and emotions were completely at odds.

Xu Qingzhu swallowed. In this quiet environment, even the sound of swallowing was loud—almost louder than her own heartbeat.

Xu Qingzhu didn't dare move anymore, hoping not to be noticed.

But a moment later, something cold landed on her face—like a folding knife.

The cold metallic sensation made her shudder, and stress-induced tears instantly flowed out.

Crystal tears slid down her cheeks. Xu Qingzhu didn't move at all, only hearing a voice say: "Baby, you're awake?"

This voice carried a hint of teasing and a few notes of intimacy.

The way she called someone "baby" was sickeningly sweet, enough to make one want to vomit.

But Xu Qingzhu didn't dare move. The cold metallic sensation kept triggering those memories, but she was trying her best to suppress them, fearing her emotions would collapse.

The saying "long illness makes a doctor"¹ had a certain degree of credibility and feasibility.

After so many years of psychological treatment, Xu Qingzhu could slightly suppress her emotions through self-hypnosis, but she couldn't maintain the same calmness as usual.

That voice sounded in her ear again: "You've been quite pleased with yourself lately."

Xu Qingzhu couldn't speak. Even wanting to question her, she could only make muffled sounds. After trying and finding she couldn't speak, she stopped even making those sounds, not daring to talk to the kidnapper, afraid of direct confrontation.

In this kind of environment, it seemed only sleep could soothe her anxious and frightened heart.

But when one finds oneself in such a dangerous environment, no one can fall asleep.

It was also an abandoned chemical factory—a place where no sunlight could reach, with only one dim yellow light illuminating the enormous factory floor, making it impossible to see clearly.

Several children were huddled together, keeping each other warm.

There were still "troublemakers," there were those who didn't fit in, there were brave ones who "stood out"—but the end result was always the same without exception: death.

That was the kidnapping case from many years ago. Groups of two or three people sat in the factory, smoking and drinking. When they chatted, they spoke in regional dialects, and even when they occasionally spoke Mandarin, it wasn't standard.

They were all dreaming of a wonderful future—what kind of luxurious life they could live after getting the ransom, how many houses they could buy, how many cars, how many wives.

The young children couldn't understand their words, but they could understand the meaning from their non-standard Mandarin.

There were even more outrageous ones who told the people inside to pick a child to take back and raise—once she grew up, she would become a wife.

They discussed those things brazenly in front of the children. Those vulgar and filthy words came out of their mouths all day long.

At first, they too were thrown in a corner, not given food to eat—just a mouthful of cold water.

Even the cold water was shared among several people from one bowl.

One little girl had broken the bowl and was beaten severely, because they accused her of trying to escape this way.

But they forgot that children only a few years old didn't have the strength to untie the knots they had tied.

The reason Xu Qingzhu was afraid of darkness was because those people, after eating and drinking their fill, got bored and played with the kidnapped children like toys.

Her eyes were covered with black cloth, so dark that not a sliver of light could get through.

Someone handed her a knife and told her to stab with it.

In front of her was Liang Shi, holding a foam board in her hands.

Footnotes:

¹ **Long illness makes a doctor (久病成醫):** A Chinese proverb meaning that someone who has been sick for a long time eventually learns enough about their condition to become like a doctor themselves. In this context, it refers to how Xu Qingzhu has learned to manage her psychological condition through years of treatment.